Studio Report - EMU Electronic Music Unit University of Adelaide

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Current Activities

2006 saw the introduction of new courses that expand the range of offerings available to undergraduate students. The aim is both to provide greater depth in certain areas, as well to give wider breadth of coverage, particularly in awareness of current trends and issues affecting music technology. A student forum was introduced that gives opportunities for the discussion of issues (one issue discussed was "What is Music Technology?"). Further, the forum has allowed for presentations to the entire student body by visiting artists and guest speakers (so far this year speakers have included Robin Minard, Warren Burt and Gordon Monro).

Students and staff have been engaged in a variety of performance activities, including Project 3 at the 2006 Adelaide Festival of the Arts, and performances at venues such as Gallery de la Catessen. EMU continues to encourage students to engage in public performance in a variety of contexts that ensure the forging of links with the wider community.

Postgraduate students are engaged in a wide variety of research projects ranging from artificial life to psychoacoustics and musicological research.

Future Developments

In 2007 EMU will introduce a new program, a VET Diploma in Music (Sound Engineering). The studio continues in its desire to bridge the apparent gap between music industry training, computer and electroacoustic music composition, and research. In this respect we confront challenges that are faced by music institutions in Australia and throughout the world. Meeting the diversity of student expectations is always difficult, especially as the variety of educational and musical backgrounds among students has noticeably increased in the last decade. It is evident that some of the comfortable assumptions of former times need to be re-examined in the light of enormous changes that have happened in the musical and educational environment of which we are part.

Bridging the gap (often the result of a combination of physical, administrative and social factors) between students studying technology and other music students is by no means easy. Restrictions imposed from without by inflexible course structures and ingrained attitudes have to be overcome. While progress has been made, it cannot be said that the battle has been won.

EMU remains committed to offering an education that is at once broad and specialised; that exposes students to the widest range of musical experiences; that challenges students to think about what they do; that gives them skills that are flexible and capable of responding to the volatile technological environment that we are currently in, and will be for the foreseeable future.

The numbers of students is ever increasing, and in particular there has been healthy growth at the postgraduate level. The long process of rebuilding (that commenced a decade ago with the founding of the Performing Arts Technology Unit after some years in which the old Elder Conservatorium Electronic Music Studio was dormant) has reached a point where we feel we are again standing on solid ground. Further developments in research (both by staff and students) and further broadening of the educational offerings of EMU are anticipated. A fruitful collaboration with Media Studies is also likely to lead to further developments.



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